

Portfolio assignment: Philosophy statement and professional development plan

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Professions

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Philosophy Statement

Diversity, inclusion, and patron-centered practice have been and continue to be the foundation of all my work in the library. Now, at the end of my first semester of the MLIS program, I have also been challenged to think critically about how patrons see the library as an institution and how they see me as a current public library paraprofessional and a future academic reference librarian.

I practice cultural humility by recognizing my power and privilege in patron interactions and acknowledging that even while teaching patrons, I must also learn from them to assist them successfully (Chávez, 2012). I do not enter into interactions with preconceptions, and I do not diagnose people: whether someone is disabled, non-neurotypical, suffering from trauma, or just one of those people who was never taught to say please and thank you, I work to react to their behavior as if they meant to treat me respectfully, and the interaction usually goes smoothly. Awareness that behavior can be affected by many factors, including trauma, creates an overarching understanding that the patron is not necessarily “bad or wrong” (PLA Social Worker Task Force & PLA, 2022).

When library staff fail to approach each interaction from a trauma-informed lens, we risk othering, stereotyping, and disrespecting the patron. We fail to encourage skill-building, confidence, and self-determination. In the long term, the patron is more information-poor due to avoiding staff engagement. This is directly contrary to libraries’ primary purpose of helping patrons gather, make sense of, and gain knowledge from, information. Librarians are responsible for ensuring that everyone has access to accurate and unbiased information

regardless of their beliefs, preconceptions, or cultural contexts to counter the misinformation, disinformation, and malinformation that is rampant in our society today.

Libraries should be safe spaces for open dialogue and the exchange of ideas, regardless of people's political beliefs. However, when I think about information access, I also think of the philosopher Karl Popper's paradox of tolerance, which states that if society is completely tolerant, including having tolerance for fascism and other suppressive philosophies, those philosophies will lead to the development of a completely intolerant society (Popper, 2013). Therefore, the one thing I pledge to be intolerant of is intolerance.

The most important task of a librarian, regardless of the type of institution, is to promote critical cultural literacy. Literacy is more than just knowing how to read and write; it is the expression of all a person can do with reading, writing, and, most importantly, critical and contextual thinking. As a librarian, it is my responsibility to help others develop these skills so that they can better understand and engage with the world around them. Focusing on the uses of literacy for social justice in my community is essential (Saunders, 2017). The use of literacy can be powerful not just as a means of information access but also as a tool for empowerment. By providing people with the tools they need to fight against injustice, critical cultural literacy can help create a more equitable society (Cooke, 2021).

Professional Development Plan

Short-term plan

I currently work as a paraprofessional at Richland Library, a public library system in Columbia, South Carolina. Though it's not perfect, I feel privileged to work at an institution committed to social justice and employee well-being at all organizational levels. My job has

allowed me to shadow the Research and Readers' Advisory department to learn how to improve my interactions with patrons. I have also gained valuable customer service experience as a member of the eReady team, which troubleshoots technical issues that other frontline library associates cannot solve. When I help patrons with their technology problems, I have learned how to strike a balance between efficiently and directly telling patrons what to do and explaining the reasoning behind my decisions to empower them to find solutions in the future.

I plan to take courses that help me hone my information-seeking and research skills to meet the information needs of students and faculty. I am also pursuing the Diversity, Equity, and Inclusion certificate to gain experience practicing cultural competence and cultural humility. Finally, I am excited to take advantage of the many opportunities for group work while studying for my MLIS. Partnership and collaboration are critical for academic librarians, who must often gain buy-in from disparate parties such as students, faculty, staff, and administrators when planning projects (Rubin & Rubin, 2020).

I have been a member of the American Library Association (ALA) and the Association for Library Service to Children (ALSC) since 2021. I have pursued many networking and professional development opportunities offered by these groups. I am a member of the ALSC Children and Technology committee, which has allowed me to suggest resources and make recommendations that ALSC members can look to for guidance when planning technology-centered programs with youth. Though I plan to work with older students and adults in the future, I have found the networking and collaboration opportunities afforded me as a member of ALSC invaluable.

Long-term plan

After graduation, I plan to work in an academic library. I plan to apply for some of the many internship programs, residencies, and fellowships available for students and new graduates, especially those from underrepresented backgrounds, who seek to work in an academic library setting. As an undergraduate, I was intimidated by authority figures, including librarians and professors. I want to demonstrate leadership at my future institution by being approachable and welcoming to all students, faculty, and staff. I especially feel that it is essential to connect with Black students and other students from intentionally marginalized communities.

As an undergraduate psychology major and having worked in marketing for a decade, I have developed a healthy respect for the benefits and limitations of quantitative and qualitative research in informing decision-making. Therefore, in addition to reference work with students and faculty, I plan to get involved in the data-driven assessment initiatives that are an important part of academic librarianship (ACRL, 2022). Just as I plan to continually improve as a librarian, I want to contribute to the continual improvement of my future institution.

I plan to become a member of the Association of College & Research Libraries (ACRL) and the Reference & User Services Association (RUSA) and continue to pursue a role as a national thought leader on an ALA, ACRL, or RUSA committee.

My librarianship philosophy is a work in progress, and I intend for it to remain so throughout my career. I take ALA's tenet of lifelong learning seriously and plan to continually reevaluate and update my guiding principles throughout my career.

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